

Building the Rationale for Medical Nutrition Certification: An Illustrative Study from Colorado



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Disclosures

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Objective

Explore rationale for nutrition certification pathways using the University of Colorado, Pediatric Nutrition and Obesity Clinical Fellowship as a case study



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Background

- Nutrition-related disease is an enduring public health challenge
- Contributes to substantial morbidity, mortality, and health care costs across the lifespan
- Lacking is a unified, standardized pathway for advanced physician training for Physician Nutrition Medicine
- Establishing a well recognized ABMS pathway will
 - support institutional accountability
 - ensure program quality
 - allow for innovation in training and clinical service models
 - Increase number of trained physicians
- Our goal is to build a cadre of physicians with recognized nutrition competency in response to the evolving healthcare needs.

Background

The Section of Pediatric Nutrition at University of Colorado is the only independent Nutrition Division in a Department of Pediatrics in a US School of Medicine

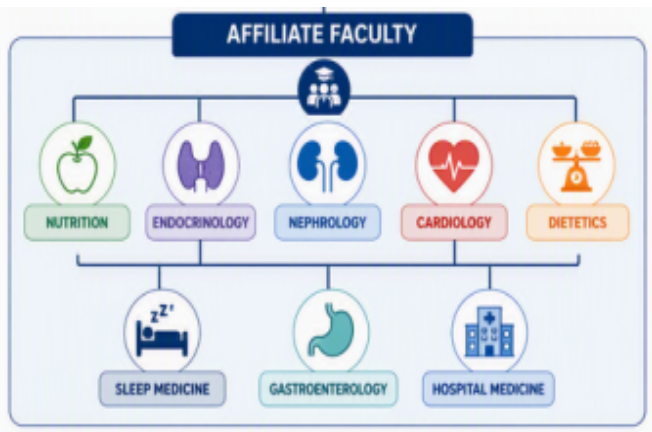
Educational portfolio is a vertically integrated program

- **Undergraduate medical education (UME)**
 - Core medical school curriculum, culinary medicine selective, MS electives
- **Graduate Medical Education (GME)**
 - Residents and Fellows electives, 1/2-day learning conference for 1st year residents -educational escape room on micronutrients/malnutrition, Food as Medicine elective
- **Advanced Clinical Fellowship**
 - One-year pediatric nutrition and obesity medicine
 - 2-year T32 Nutrition Research Fellowship in Nutrition
- **Faculty and Community Education (FCE)**

Overview of Clinical Obesity and Nutrition Fellowship

- 1-year Fellowship
- Eligibility: Pediatrics, Med/Peds, or Family Medicine Residency-trained physicians
- Clinical Experience
 - 4 half days per week in Undernutrition and obesity clinic
 - Inpatient call for Medical Nutrition Consultation Service
 - Outpatient PCP e-consults
- Fellowship Mentorship
- Portfolio of learning resources
- Trained 17 MD/DOs since 2006

Overview of Clinical Obesity and Nutrition Fellowship



Other core rotations: NICU, PICU, obesity subspecialty clinics, metabolic and bariatric surgery

Electives: Integrative Medicine, NICU follow-up, Genetics/Metabolism, Sports Medicine, Food Allergy, Adolescent Med – Eating Disorders, Breastfeeding, Aerodigestive, GI, Endocrine –bone health

Case presentations and Nutrition Case Discussions, Collaborative Case Reviews, joint GI/Nutrition Case Conference

Research and Scholarship: QI project, participate in research or T32 application

Can be followed by Nutrition T32 research fellowship
Can add a one-year global health experience

Board Eligibility: Physician Nutrition Specialist and American Board of Obesity Medicine

Overview of Clinical Obesity and Nutrition Fellowship

Key Principles

- Collaborative leadership & partnerships
- Fellow-centered excellence in learning, scholarship and practice
- Accountability and quality
- Alignment with Department of Pediatrics and School of Medicine goals



Curricular component: Entrustable Professional Activity (EPA)

Focus of an EPA is on an observable activity, rather than a learning objective or competency

Trusted to observe only	Trusted to execute with direct supervision and coaching	Trusted to execute with indirect supervision and discussion of information conveyed for most simple and some complex cases	Trusted to execute with indirect supervision but may require discussion of information conveyed for a few complex cases	Trusted to execute without supervision
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EPA 1. Diagnosis of Common Nutritional Issues in Infants, Children, and Adolescents

EPA 2. Care of infants, children, and adolescents with malnutrition, feeding difficulties, and nutritional deficiencies

EPA 3. Management of children, adolescents and young adults with obesity

Exploring certification

Rationale

- Recognition of an advanced skillset

- Impact of nutrition on individual and population health

- Need for indepth nutrition expertise in healthcare services

- Implications for reimbursement

- Expertise in teaching nutrition education

What pathways can (should) be considered?

- Establish ACGME-accredited specialty- ABMS Board?

- National Board of Physician Nutrition Specialists (NBPNS)

- ABMS Focused Practice Designation

[National Board of Physician Nutrition Specialists](#)

What about establishing ABMS Board of Nutrition Certification?

More challenges than opportunities

- 1. Nutrition is highly interdisciplinary**
- 2. Limited workforce size**
- 3. Clinical nutrition overlaps heavily with other specialties**
- 4. High administrative burden**

ABMS generally expects a specialty to demonstrate: A unique body of knowledge, distinct clinical practice, sufficient workforce demand

Creating a standalone board could fragment expertise that already exists within multiple specialties

National Board of Physician Nutrition Specialists (NBPNS)

A **Physician Nutrition Specialist (PNS)** is typically a physician already board certified in an ABMS-recognized specialty (such as Internal Medicine, Family Medicine, Pediatrics, Endocrinology, Gastroenterology, Surgery, or Critical Care) who has additional expertise in clinical nutrition

PNS physicians often:

- Manage obesity and metabolic disorders
- Direct nutrition support programs (enteral and parenteral nutrition)
- Treat malnutrition and nutrition-related diseases
- Lead multidisciplinary nutrition teams
- Teach nutrition in academic medical centers

ABMS Focused Practice Designation

Recognition of the need for specialized practice areas beyond subspecialty certification

- Active board certification in a qualifying specialty
- Documented focused clinical practice

ABMS formally expanded the modern FPD framework in 2017

Expanded to multiple specialties within surgery, pathology, emergency medicine, Hospital Medicine

Lifestyle FPD approved by ABMS in 2026 and administered by ABPM (preventive Medicine), But significant gaps with Nutrition scope of practice

NBPNS and ABMS Focused practice designation

Question	NBPNS	ABMS Focused Practice
Separate nutrition credential?	Yes	No
ABMS certification?	No	Yes, through an ABMS board
Demonstrates advanced nutrition expertise?	Yes	Yes
Specifically designed for nutrition medicine?	Yes	Depends on sponsoring board
Commonly used to identify physician nutrition experts?	Yes	Less commonly discussed than PNS certification

Can the pathway be complementary?



NBPNS answers: "Who is an expert in nutrition?"

The National Board of Physician Nutrition Specialists remains the content expert and competency assessor

An ABMS Focused Practice designation answers: "How does organized medicine and broader community recognize this expertise?"

The FPD provides broader institutional recognition (credentialing systems) and aligns with ABMS certification infrastructure

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What would be the ideal sweet spot?

1. Primary Specialty Board Certification
2. Nutrition Fellowship (or equivalent structured training)
3. Required NBPNS/PNS Certification
4. ABMS Focused Practice Recognition in Clinical Nutrition



Thank you



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